

w3.1- Team Training Needs

- Data analysis



Because of its
emphasis on objective,



- Company-specific information including the strategic plan



In addition, Six
Sigma teams will also



w3.1- Team Training Needs.mp4

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- Team facilitation

However, even with all of
this important knowledge,



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- Effective Communication
- Conflict Management



Finally, there are
interpersonal skills



Importance of Team Training

No matter how enthusiastic team members are about their project, that enthusiasm is not enough to ensure a good outcome. Teams of any type must be given the skills necessary to be effective in their assigned task, or they will fail.

A primary aspect of **team facilitation** is providing the team with the skills they need to accomplish their charter. A **team facilitator** is recommended for every project team to provide necessary support and help ensure success.

Required Skills for Six Sigma Teams

Six Sigma Project teams require a variety of skills spanning methodology, data analysis, organizational knowledge, and interpersonal dynamics.

1. Six Sigma and Process Methodology Skills

All teams should be trained in the core concepts of the Six Sigma philosophy:

- **The DMAIC Model:** Training in the process analysis and problem-solving techniques used by the DMAIC model is essential.
- **Lean Concepts:** These are also important, especially for teams tasked with reducing waste.

2. Data and Objective Analysis Skills

Because Six Sigma emphasizes objective, fact-based decisions, effective data analysis is a critical skill:

- **Effective Data Analysis:** This is considered a **Black Belt-level skill**.
- **Support for Green Belts:** If a project team is led by a Green Belt, they may need a Black Belt to assist with the complex data analysis.

3. Company-Specific Information

To make informed decisions about the best direction for improvement, teams need information about the **organization itself**. This information is typically provided by the **team's Champion or Process Owner**. This training includes:

- Costs and Budgets
- Customer Requirements
- Process and System Structure and Function
- Company Goals and Objectives

4. Team Facilitation and Interpersonal Skills

Even with all the technical knowledge, teams cannot be effective if they cannot successfully work together.

- **Team Facilitation Skills:** Team leaders must be knowledgeable about the facilitation skills covered in the previous module including how to hold effective team meetings. These skills can prevent most of the common problems associated with unsuccessful teams.
- **Interpersonal Skills:** These are vital to any successful team and should always be included in the training. This includes techniques for:
 - Effective team communication
 - How to keep conflict **constructive** while maintaining team creativity (Communication skills will be the focus of the next lesson.)

w3.2- Communication Skills for Project Teams

Barriers to Effective Communication

- Filtering
- Selective perception
- Emotions
- Language differences
- Nonverbal cues
- Organizational status and power differences
- Differences in goals and needs
- Inadequate formal communication channels



Barriers to effective
communication.



Overcoming Barriers to Communication

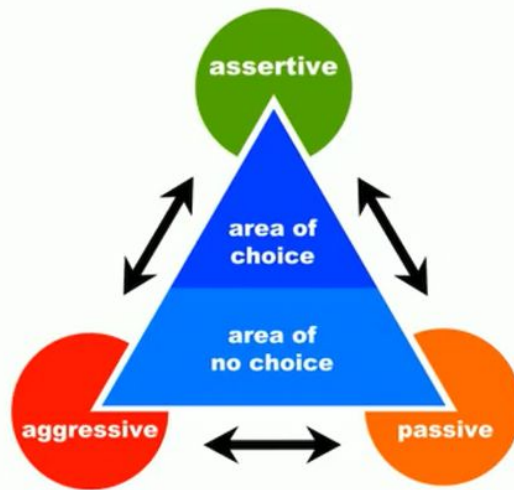


- Use feedback
- Simplify language
- Constrain emotions
- Watch non-verbal cues
- Know your listeners
- Speak assertively

Overcoming barriers
to communication.



Assertive Speaking

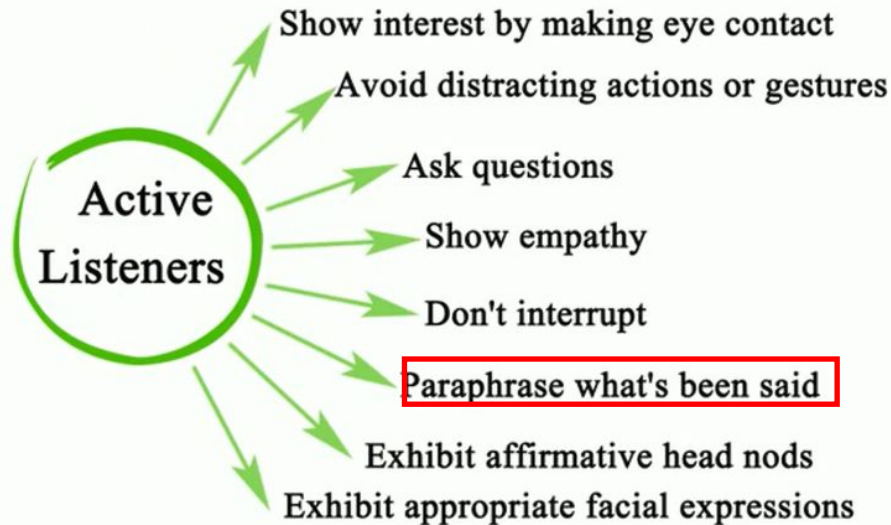


- Passive behavior suppresses.
- Aggressive behavior expresses.
- Assertive behavior communicates.

Finally, speak assertively.
Assertive speaking.



Eight Behaviors of Active Listeners



Eight behaviors of
active listeners.



Barriers to Effective Communication

Effective communication is often hampered by several barriers that Six Sigma team leaders must be aware of to reduce their negative impact:

- **Filtering:** The deliberate manipulation of information to make it appear more favorable to the **receiver**. This is common when communicating with people in higher power positions or those we don't want to upset.
- **Selective Perception:** The receiver selectively hears or sees communications based on their needs, motivations, experiences, background, or other personal characteristics. This is **not a conscious decision** everyone does it.
- **Emotions:** Both positive and negative emotions (happy, sad, excited, bored) can influence how a message is sent or interpreted.
- **Language:** Words can mean different things to different people. This includes not only **different languages** (like English vs. Spanish) but also differences **in terminology** across jobs, companies, and departments.

- **Nonverbal Cues:** Body language and facial expressions must be consistent with the spoken message. If the cues are inconsistent (e.g., smiling while delivering bad news), the receiver can become confused, and clarity suffers.
- **Organizational Status and Power Differences:** This can inhibit communication, especially when people are reluctant to pass bad news upward.
- **Differences in Goals and Needs:** People perceive situations and messages in their own terms.
- **Inadequate Formal Communication Channels:** This reduces overall communication effectiveness within the organization.

✓ Overcoming Communication Barriers

Here are helpful techniques for overcoming these barriers:

- **Use Feedback:** Ask message receivers to **paraphrase back** what you told them in their own words. Simple repetition does not ensure processing and retention.
- **Simplify Your Language:** Avoid terminology that the receiver may not be familiar with; use common words and phrasing.
- **Constrain Emotions:** It's usually **a good idea to delay** important or complex communications until both the sender and receiver are less emotional.
- **Watch Nonverbal Cues:** Ensure your body language and facial expression are **consistent** with your message.
- **Know Your Listeners:** The more you know about their preconceptions, experiences, and education, the better you **can tailor the message to ensure correct interpretation.**
- **Speak Assertively:** This is critical for effective communication.

Assertive Speaking

Assertive speaking is key to effective communication and contrasts with two other styles:

Communication Style	Description	Impact on Team
Passive	Accepts messages without response or resistance because they are afraid. They act powerless and don't say what needs to be said.	Results in poor team decisions due to a lack of needed information.
Aggressive	Typically shows anger or emotion by speaking loudly or demanding. They try to dominate others through blame, criticism, or intimidation.	Blocks communication and can lead to conflict rather than understanding.
Assertive	Always honest, speaking openly and confidently. They say what needs to be said calmly and unemotionally , dealing directly with the problem.	Ensures everyone knows what they need to know to make the right decisions .

Eight Behaviors of Active Listeners

Effective communication requires commitment from the message receiver, who must be willing to take responsibility for getting the full intended meaning from the speaker. This requires **active listening**.

Tips for being an active listener:

1. **Make Eye Contact:** Focuses attention and encourages the speaker.
2. **Avoid Distracting Actions or Gestures:** Avoid actions that suggest your mind is elsewhere.
3. **Ask Questions:** Provides clarification, ensures understanding, and assures the speaker you are listening.
4. **Show Empathy:** Try to understand what the speaker wants to communicate rather than what you want to understand.
5. **Avoid Interrupting:** Let the speaker complete their message; **don't try to second-guess** their thoughts.
6. **Paraphrase the Speaker's Words:** Repeat in your own words what you think the speaker said so they can confirm your interpretation.
7. **Exhibit Affirmative Nods and Appropriate Facial Expressions:** This shows interest and encourages the speaker to continue.

w3.3- Conflict Management Skills for Project Teams

Keeping Conflict Constructive



Sources of Team Conflict



Sources of team conflict.

Conflict Handling Strategies



- Collaboration – we both win
- Compromise – we both win some and lose some
- Accommodation – you win, I lose
- Forcing / Dominating – I win, you lose
- Avoidance – I'm not going to get involved



satisfy all conflicting parties for
a win-win outcome.

Other Ways to Resolve Conflict

- Encourage open communication
- Practice active listening
- Clarify messages/problems
- Add relevant information/alternatives
- Monitor the problem-solving process
- Keep interaction fair
- Focus on problems and behaviors, not personalities or people
- Encourage rationality and discourage power plays
- Review and confirm commitment to solutions



Other ways to resolve conflict.

This lesson focuses on **conflict management skills** for Six Sigma Project teams. The goal is to keep the conflict that arises from different perspectives **constructive, creative, and productive**, preventing it from becoming destructive.



Why Conflict is Essential

Conflict is common on project teams, and it's deliberately encouraged by selecting team members who **have different roles and perspectives** on the problem. The resulting conflict can lead to **greater creativity and better solutions**, provided it is managed effectively.

The key is to maintain a level of conflict that results in **open discussion** and the **free exchange of different viewpoints** without allowing it to become personal or destructive.

💡 Sources of Team Conflict

Understanding the source of conflict helps identify the best management strategy. Common reasons for conflict on Six Sigma teams include:

- **Different views of the problem or lack of clarity in team objectives:** This is common during the **storming stage** of team development and can lead to frustration. The team's **charter** is key to avoiding this.
- **Lack of understanding of team roles, responsibilities, and expectations:** Common during the **forming stage**, this can cause fear, frustration, and perceived differences in contribution. These must be clarified early on.
- **Different values or beliefs:** These can result from different perspectives, departments, or levels. While different perspectives lead to more creative solutions, they cannot be allowed to create barriers.
- **Decision-making process:** How decisions will be handled should be addressed during the forming stage so everyone understands and agrees.
- **Lack of effective communication.**
- **Unresolved prior conflicts or personality clashes:** The team leader should be aware of these when selecting members and ensure members can set them aside.

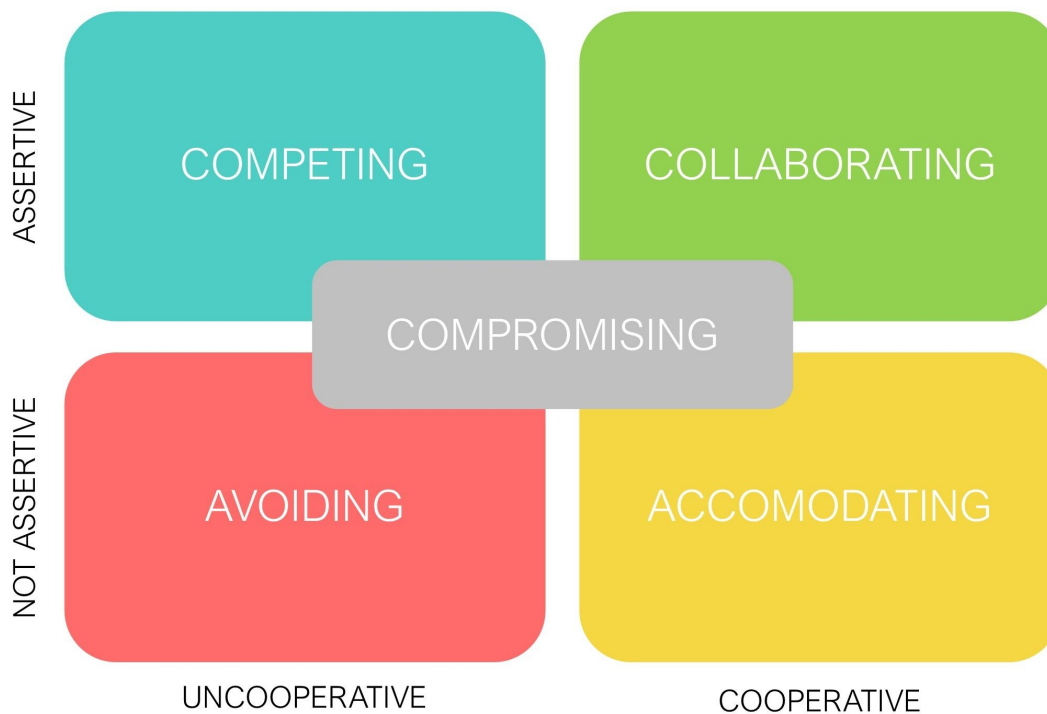
Symptoms of Destructive Conflict

There are many warning signs that conflict is becoming destructive and needs intervention:

- Team members become **impatient** with one another.
- Ideas are **attacked** before they are completely expressed.
- Members **refuse to compromise** or constantly disagree.
- Team members become **aggressive communicators** making comments with great vehemence or emotion.
- Subtle **personal attacks** or belittling the group's ability begins.
- Members accuse one another of not understanding **the basic issue or distort each other's contributions.**
- Conflict among a few members begins to create **apathy** among others.
- Team effectiveness **will likely decline** if the conflict is left unresolved.

Conflict Handling Strategies

There is no single "right" or "wrong" method; the best strategy depends on the organizational culture and the specific moment of conflict.



1. Collaboration (Win-Win):

- Requires identifying a **new alternative** that satisfies all conflicting parties.
- **Best when:** Both views are equally important and everyone's agreement is needed.
- **Drawback:** Can be very time-consuming.

2. Compromise (Win Some, Lose Some):

- Requires everyone to win some and lose some.
- **Best when:** Two opponents have **equal power and equal goals**, and taking the time for collaboration is not worth the effort.
- **Note:** Works best when sides are not too far apart so that neither side feels like they lost too much.

3. Accommodation (Giving In):

- One side of the conflict gives in to the other side.
- **Best when:** An issue is more important to one side than the other, and giving in will **not negatively affect the team's final outcome**.

4. Forcing/Dominating:

- The side with more power forces its position on the other side.
- **Appropriate when: Quick decisions are needed,** or when one side has **information or knowledge** that the other lacks, and not forcing the decision could result in a negative outcome.

5. Avoiding:

- Ignoring the conflict altogether.
- **Best when: Dealing with less important issues** or when the potential damage from the conflict outweighs the benefits of a resolution.
- **Also good when:** Emotions are high (at least temporarily).

Other Ways to Resolve Conflict

Since conflict often results from communication problems, techniques to improve communication are helpful:

- Encourage **open communication** and **active listening** among conflicting parties.
- **Clarify messages or problems** and add relevant information or alternatives.
- Team leaders should **monitor the problem-solving process** to ensure interaction is fair and the agreed-upon decision-making method is followed.
- Remind the team to focus on **problems and behaviors, not personalities or people**.
- Encourage **rationality and the use of facts** over opinions, **and discourage power plays**.
- Review and confirm the team's commitment to the solutions once they're reached to ensure everyone understands and agrees.